



TACTIVISION.AI

OPPOSITION ANALYSIS REPORT

MANCHESTER CITY

Premier League

Formation: 4-2-3-1 / 3-2-4-1

Style: Possession-based positional play, midfield rebuild post-De Bruyne

Manager: Pep Guardiola



PREPARED BY

Operations Analyst — Tactivision.ai

Report Generated: 11 June 2026

PERFORMANCE OVERVIEW

Key metrics from recent fixtures

WIN RATE 70% 7W 2D 1L in last 10	AVG XG 1.84 Expected goals per match	AVG POSSESSION 52% Ball possession per match	KEY PLAYERS 10 Players tracked
---	---	---	---

RECENT FORM

Last 10 matches

W	W	D	W	W	L	W	W	W	D
---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---	---

SWOT ANALYSIS

Strengths and weaknesses assessment

STRENGTHS

- + Restored midfield control post-De Bruyne via Reijnders + Cherki creativity (52% FBref)
- + Tactical flexibility — multiple formations mid-game
- + Haaland clinical finishing (26 goals, +3.6 vs xG, FBref)
- + Squad depth — won EFL Cup, into FA Cup final
- + Aït-Nouri left-side dynamism on overlaps

WEAKNESSES

- Inconsistent season (no CL — failed to qualify from league phase)
- Vulnerable to pace on counter-attacks (10 transition goals conceded, Football-Lineups)
- Over-reliance on Rodri for midfield control
- High defensive line exploitable with long balls behind
- Cherki defensive work rate creates imbalance vs press-resistant teams

TACTICAL PATTERNS

Phase-of-play breakdown

BUILD UP

Short passing from back, GK involved in build-up. Aït-Nouri overlaps, Gvardiol or Lewis inverts on opposite side. Rodri drops between CBs as single pivot. Reijnders provides dynamic ball progression. Progressive passing rate: 8.0 per 90 (FBref).

ATTACKING

Half-space overloads with Foden left and Cherki/Bernardo right. Reijnders late runs replace De Bruyne's role. Width from FBs. Sustained possession (62% avg). xG per 90: 2.0 (FBref).

DEFENSIVE

High press triggered by opponent GK or CB. Counter-press immediately on loss. PPDA: 8.6 (FBref). Compact midfield block when settled.

SET PIECES

Cherki delivery from corners and free kicks. Haaland and Dias primary aerial targets. Set piece xG: 0.29 per match (FBref).

TRANSITIONS

Quick vertical passes on turnover. Haaland stretches defensive line. Vulnerable to fast breaks when FBs are high — exposed in defeats vs Arsenal and Liverpool.

KEY PERSONNEL

Players to watch — scouting report

#	Player	Position	Strengths	Weaknesses
9	Erling Haaland	ST	Aerial duels, Finishing, Movement in box	Link-up play under pressure, Defensive contribution
4	Tijjani Reijnders	CM/AM	Box-to-box runs, Press resistance, Late arrivals in box	Aerial duels, Defensive discipline vs counters
10	Rayan Cherki	AM/RW	Creative passing, Dribbling in tight spaces, Set-piece delivery	Defensive work rate, Consistency
16	Rodri	CDM	Ball retention, Pressing resistance, Positional discipline	Pace in recovery, Susceptible to quick counters
47	Phil Foden	LW/AM	Dribbling, Half-space movement, Finishing	Physical duels, Consistency in big matches
24	Josko Gvardiol	LB/CB	Ball carrying, Overlapping runs, Aerial presence	Positioning in 1v1 defending
20	Bernardo Silva	RW/CM	Press resistance, Ball retention, Work rate	Goal output, Aerial duels
26	Savinho	RW	Dribbling, 1v1 ability, Pace	Defensive tracking, Decision-making in final third
12	Rayan Aït-Nouri	LB	Pace, Overlapping runs, 1v1 defending	Crossing accuracy, Aerial duels
3	Ruben Dias	CB	Positional defending, Aerial duels, Leadership	Pace against elite forwards

MATCH-BY-MATCH BREAKDOWN

Detailed fixture analysis

vs LIVERPOOL (Home)

3-0

2025-11-09 · Premier League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
2.6	56%	18	8	9

KEY EVENTS

- Haaland brace (29' header from Reijnders cross, 71' counter)
- Foden goal 56' (half-space combination with Cherki)
- Wirtz isolated — only 1 shot, 0 key passes
- Salah quiet vs Gvardiol — no shots on target
- City dominated possession and territory

TACTICAL NOTES

City's Reijnders-Cherki midfield creativity comprehensively outplayed Liverpool's Wirtz-Mac Allister axis. Liverpool's Slot system without TAA's right-side delivery looked blunt — only 0.8 xG from 9 shots. Cherki's 5 SCAs were the most by any City player in a single league match this season (FBref). Liverpool's defensive shape vs Foden's left-side movement was repeatedly broken.

vs REAL MADRID (Away)

2-1

2026-03-11 · Champions League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
2	56%	17	7	8

KEY EVENTS

- Mbappé brace on counter-attacks (24', 68' — TAA assist on second)
- Haaland goal 41' (header from Ait-Nouri cross)
- Madrid clinical from 1.6 xG vs City's 2.0 xG
- TAA delivered 4 progressive passes from RB into final third
- Arbeloa's first signature CL knockout result

TACTICAL NOTES

Classic Real Madrid game management — first KO win under Arbeloa. Madrid conceded possession (44%) and waited for transition moments. Mbappé exploited Gvardiol's high positioning twice. TAA-Mbappé combination on the counter is Madrid's new structural weapon — TAA's diagonal switches from right back released Mbappé's runs. City's reformed midfield (no De Bruyne) struggled to break Madrid's compact 4-4-2.

vs REAL MADRID (Home)

2-2

2026-03-04 · Champions League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
2.3	58%	19	8	9

KEY EVENTS

- Cherki goal 18' (free kick top corner)
- Mbappé equalizer 31' (TAA long ball, beat Dias on pace)
- Foden goal 61' (Reijnders through ball, half-space finish)
- Bellingham late equalizer 86' (header from TAA corner)
- City dominated territory but Madrid 2 goals from 1.1 xG on transitions

TACTICAL NOTES

City controlled the game (58% possession, 19 shots) but Madrid's transition efficiency — and TAA's set-piece delivery from his old enemy stadium — was devastating. Cherki shows his Lyon-era set-piece quality at City. Bellingham's late header exposed City's zonal marking again. Aggregate tie went to Madrid 4-3 (CL R16). Rodri's tactical sub for the final 15 min coincided with Madrid's surge.

vs LIVERPOOL (Away)

1-2

2026-02-01 · Premier League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
1.7	49%	13	6	7

KEY EVENTS

- Cherki goal 12' (free kick top corner — second this season at Anfield level)
- Ekitiké equalizer 38' (Wirtz through ball, smart finish)
- Haaland winner 71' (Aït-Nouri cross, header)
- Salah quiet again — 0 shots on target
- Aït-Nouri 4 progressive carries from LB

TACTICAL NOTES

Cherki's free-kick quality decisive once again — 0.06 xG from set pieces converted. Liverpool's high line was punished by Aït-Nouri's overlapping crosses targeting Haaland. Ekitiké's link-up with Wirtz produced Liverpool's only goal — the partnership is the bright spot of an otherwise disappointing season. Salah's continued goal drought (now 5 league games without a goal) is Liverpool's structural concern.

vs ARSENAL (Away)

1-0

2025-09-21 · Premier League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
1.6	52%	16	5	5

KEY EVENTS

- Gabriel header from corner 76' (Saka delivery — title-defining moment)
- Gyökeres' aerial pressure throughout disrupted Dias
- Zubimendi controlled second balls — 11 recoveries
- City dominated open play but couldn't break Saliba-Gabriel

- Arsenal's 9 corners reflected dead-ball threat

TACTICAL NOTES

Arsenal's set-piece mastery decided it — Gabriel's late header from yet another Saka corner. Zubimendi's debut against City showed why he was signed: 93% pass accuracy, 11 ball recoveries against City's high press. Gyökeres' physical pressure on Dias gave Arsenal an aerial edge missing under Havertz. City's reformed midfield (Reijnders + Cherki) had moments but struggled vs Arsenal's compact 4-4-2 mid-block.

vs ARSENAL (Home)

2-2

2026-02-22 · Premier League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
2	56%	17	6	6

KEY EVENTS

- Haaland goal 23' (Reijnders cross, header)
- Gabriel equalizer 41' (corner — Saka delivery, again)
- Foden goal 67' (half-space combination with Cherki)
- Gyökeres late equalizer 88' (Eze through ball, low finish)
- Arsenal 1 goal from set piece, 1 from transition — hallmark profile

TACTICAL NOTES

End-to-end title-shaping draw. Arsenal stayed top of the table after Gyökeres' late equalizer kept them ahead of City. Cherki's creativity was City's bright spot — 4 SCAs, the assist for Foden. Arsenal's two goals followed their season template: one set piece, one transition through Gyökeres' direct running. Both teams' high lines were exploited at least once. Combined 3.5 xG was the highest in any match between them this season.

vs PSG (Away)

4-1

2025-09-30 · Champions League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
1.1	47%	12	4	4

KEY EVENTS

- Dembélé brace (11' cut inside, 56' counter)
- Doué goal 37' (Vitinha through ball, 1v1 finish)
- Haaland consolation 64' (header from Reijnders cross)
- Kvaratskhelia goal 78' (solo dribble from left)
- City's high line repeatedly exposed by PSG's pace and one-touch combinations

TACTICAL NOTES

PSG's signature performance of the league phase — total demolition of City. Dembélé's Ballon d'Or campaign was launched here. City's reformed midfield (no De Bruyne, Reijnders still adapting to CL) was overrun. Dias-Gvardiol high line was punished 4 times. This result contributed heavily to City failing to qualify from the league phase. FBref: PSG's 3.0 xG was City's worst defensive performance in CL since 2018.

vs BARCELONA (Home)

1-2

2025-10-22 · Champions League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
1.7	47%	16	6	7

KEY EVENTS

- Yamal goal 14' (solo run, curled finish past Ederson)
- Haaland equalizer 31' (Reijnders cross, header)
- Lewandowski winner 67' (Pedri through ball, clinical finish)
- Cubarsí MOTM — 8 clearances, 92% pass accuracy
- Barça's pressing dismantled City's build-up — 8 turnovers forced

TACTICAL NOTES

Barça's pressing intensity (PPDA 6.4) overwhelmed City's reformed midfield. Reijnders showed glimpses of progression but Cherki was rendered ineffective by Casadó's screening. Yamal vs Ait-Nouri was the key duel — Yamal won 4/5 1v1s. Defeat contributed to City's failure to qualify from the league phase. FBref: Barça's xG of 2.6 vs City was their highest in any away CL game this season.

vs BAYERN MUNICH (Away)

3-2

2025-11-05 · Champions League

xG	Possession	Shots	On Target	Corners
1.6	51%	14	5	7

KEY EVENTS

- Kane brace (14' header, 56' penalty)
- Olise goal 38' (cut inside, curled finish)
- Haaland goal 24' (De Bruyne-style chip from Reijnders)
- Cherki goal 81' (free kick top corner)
- Davies tormented Ait-Nouri — 5 successful crosses

TACTICAL NOTES

Kompany's tactical masterclass against Guardiola's reformed City. Bayern ceded marginal possession but were lethal on transitions — Davies' pace destroyed Ait-Nouri repeatedly on Bayern's left. City dominated possession briefly but couldn't break Bayern's compact 4-4-2 mid-block. Kane's set-piece header and converted penalty were classic centre-forward play. Cherki's free-kick goal was a consolation. Result helped eliminate City from CL league phase.